

prospect" with the potential for a positive business relationship. Here's a simple test: if you have a reason to call a "prospect" back, you have upgraded the relationship to the "qualified prospect" level.

A "customer" is a "qualified prospect" for whom you've written at least one ticket.

Soon I began to suspect that I was ill-prepared to become a stockbroker. This had nothing to do with my lacking an M.B.A. degree or my having failed calculus in college. What worked against me the most was never having taken a drama course. The one accountant in the bunch confided that he, too, felt out of place and that his education was a handicap. Throughout the training, he'd had trouble probing for client feedback, and asked too many closed-ended questions in a row.

Lance Jencks, the poet from Southern California whom I befriended, had the greatest advantage. Since he'd already done O'Neill, Becket, and *commedia del l'arte*, not to mention the scripts for the oil-and-gas leases, he could overcome stalls and restate needs without even thinking about it.

In the daily practice sessions, one trainee would play the broker and another would play the client, then they'd switch, and after that they'd evaluate each other. Were they too pushy? Did they close? Did they build rapport? Once they were a person short on the client end and invited me to sit in. This was fun. It amused me to hear many of the familiar catchwords and arguments from my earlier conversations with actual brokers. Such lines as: "Nothing has changed even though your stock has drifted lower," or "What you're looking for is something with growth potential," or "We're long-term oriented" come directly from the dialogues and were practiced over and over. The new brokers could repeat them in a coma.

Those with poor memories were encouraged to prepare cue cards that could be taken home and flipped during phone conversations with actual customers. I saw cards for how to introduce the tax-free bond, what to say about mutual funds, how to sell the retirement account, and even a card for what to say when the client complains, "But I don't have any money." At Prudential-Bache,